

6.2 IMAP Vs. POP3

Now, let's look at IMAP vs. POP3 (forget about the expansions; no-one will ask you). In simple terms, in IMAP, your mail program manipulates the mails on the mail server. Most actions happen on the server; it's like you issuing commands for things to happen remotely (on the server). In contrast, in POP3, you *download* your mails once and for all. When you click a button to receive your mails, they come to your computer, and are gone from the server. Your mails are now like pieces of data on your computer, which you can manipulate (on your computer) using your mail program.

That's the technical difference; what does it mean for you? Well, take two cases: person J, a frequent traveller, who uses IMAP, and person Q, a student who uses only one computer (at home), and uses POP3.

J is using his laptop on a journey. He connects to the Net using a wireless connection, and is billed according to data transfer. He fires up his mail program and tells it to fetch his mail folder list (which is possible only because he's using IMAP). He looks through the list and sees there are fifteen new messages in the Inbox. He then gets the message *headers* (information about the message) only, not the messages in their entirety. This, too, is possible only with IMAP. He sees that someone has sent him two 12 MB mails; they are the same mail, and the sender sent it twice by mistake. He deletes one of them without even opening it (IMAP allows this). He downloads the other.

Then, J notices that ten of the fifteen mails are all from a particular client, and he doesn't need to read them now. He creates a folder on the server called "Some Client", and moves those ten messages to that folder (you need IMAP to do this).

Two days later, J logs on to the Net from a cyber-café. He double-clicks the mail program icon, goes to fetch his mail, goes directly to the "Some Client" folder, and downloads them all.

See what's going on? Everything is happening on the server. The mail program is being used to fire commands at the server, as it were. Nothing is deleted from the server unless (a) J actually issues a command to delete them, or (b) if J marks a message for